

Why are dads stressed out?

■ New economic forces, such as global competition, create an increasingly fluid job market. It demands committed employees at a time when loyalty is low. Salaries are zooming, but hiring and firing are easier. Dads work longer hours to prove their indispensability.

■ Shoulder more responsibility and risk or slide down the economic ladder, says the market. It prefers nimble, younger people with constantly adaptable skills. Dads are under pressure to acquire new skills and work towards a greater future.

■ Invasive technology—from vibrating BlackBerrys, always-on Internet connectivity, to midnight teleconferencing with colleagues abroad—makes it harder for dads to detach from work at home.

■ More moms enter the workforce. For every five men, there is one woman who works in an income-generating activity in urban India today. Dads are left scrambling to become the full-fledged co-parents their wives now need them to be.

■ Modern parenting, post-globalisation, demands a more accessible father. Families are child-centric, children don't hold dads in awe. Fathers are not expected to be just the providers and disciplinarians. Caught between old values and new, dads are confused.

Stressed Dads

Career moms' struggles make daily headlines. But with today's stressful workplace, cut-throat competition, extended hours and travel, dads are now facing a serious challenge in parenting and striving to redefine the idea of fatherhood.